



LIBYA

Capital city: Tripoli
Area: 679,358 sq miles (1,759,540 sq km)
Population: 5,600,000
Official language: Arabic
Major religions: Muslim 97%, other 3%
Government: Dictatorship
Currency: Libyan dinar
Adult literacy rate: 82%
Life expectancy: 72 years
People per doctor: 769
Televisions: 126 per 1,000 people

LIBYA

SITUATED ON THE MEDITERRANEAN COAST between Egypt and Algeria, Libya is the fourth largest country in Africa. It has been part of the Roman, Byzantine, Arab, and Ottoman empires, and from 1911 to 1943 was an Italian colony. The Sahara covers about 90 percent of the country, so farming is only possible along the coastal strip, where many people work as sheep or goat herders. The discovery of oil in 1959 very quickly transformed Libya from a poor to a wealthy country. Many foreigners have since arrived to work in the oil industry.

OIL AND GAS

The production of oil and gas dominates the Libyan economy, with oil making up 98 percent of the country's exports. Before oil was discovered, Libya's major exports were rushes (river plants) and scrap metal. Most of the oil is produced in western Libya, but there are also some offshore oil reserves.

As the oil industry has grown, so have Libya's cities, providing more houses, jobs, and services. Some 88 percent of the population now resides in cities. Before this, many people lived as farmers or nomads.

Where people live



88% live in cities

12% live in the country



FAMILY GROUPS

Most Libyans are Arabs, with some Berbers and Tuaregs in the south. Almost all are Muslim. They belong to large, extended family groups called tribes or clans. The clan is an important part of society and also has an influence on politics. Many of Colonel Gadhafi's government ministers are members of his clan. People's names often reveal which clan they belong to.



COLONEL GADHAFI

Since 1969, Libya has been ruled by Colonel Muammar Gadhafi, who overthrew the king to become president. Gadhafi rules through military committees. His politics are a very personal mix of socialism, Islam, and Arab nationalism. Since all political parties were banned in 1971, any opposition to Gadhafi's rule has to come from outside Libya. Colonel Gadhafi's support in the past for terrorist organizations has sometimes brought him into conflict with Western governments.



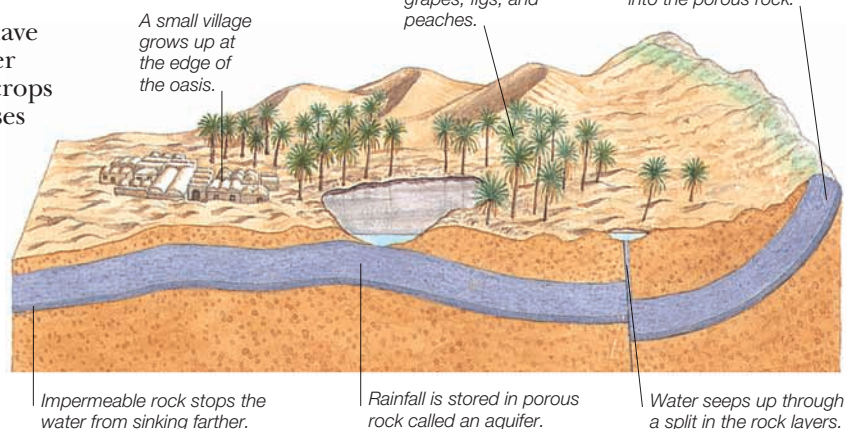
OASIS TOWN

In the vast, arid desert, small towns and villages have grown up around oases. Here, underground water rises to create rare patches of fertile land where crops are grown. The communities that live around oases rely on farming, receiving money from relations working in the cities, and dealing with passing traders. In the past, oasis towns were important stopping places for camel caravans transporting goods across the desert. Today, many of these journeys are made by truck instead.



ROMAN RUINS

Signs of Libya's rich classical past can still be seen in its many historical ruins. It has some of the finest Roman ruins in North Africa, such as the impressive site of Leptis Magna, which has a forum, aqueduct, and amphitheater (shown left). This port was founded by the Phoenicians in about 800 BC and became a major center for trade with Africa. It was then part of the Roman Empire, before the Arab invasions of the 7th century led to the city's downfall.



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